

When you have found the *who*, *what*, *where*, *when*, and *why* information in the beginning of a news story, decide whether or not to continue reading. If you do read the rest of the article, skim it by skipping to places where words are capitalized or where there are numbers, or to any points that particularly interest you. Most importantly, don't get lost in all the words; practice reading only what you need to read within a selection.

MAKING INFERENCES

There are two basic kinds of reading comprehension.

1. When you are able to use the author's words to answer a comprehension question, it is your *factual comprehension* that is being tested.
2. Sometimes, however, the information is not directly stated, so you must infer a meaning using your own reasoning and logic. This type of understanding is sometimes referred to as *inferential comprehension*.

Imagine that you are at a friend's house. It is 11:00 p.m. and your host starts to look at his watch and yawn out loud. Although he never actually tells you to leave, he implies and you infer that it is time for you to go home.

Daily newspapers publish advice columns for everything from successful vegetable gardening to curing yourself of high blood pressure. The following passage answers questions about car problems.

Directions: Read the following passage and answer the questions that follow.

Sample Reading Passage 7

Q. My engine cranks all right. But why won't it start up?

A. Think twice. Are you following the exact starting procedure given in your owner's manual? Next, pin down the trouble area by checking these possibilities: (1) gasoline, (2) spark, and (3) air-gasoline ratio.

- (5) 1. First make sure you have gasoline in the tank. If that's not the problem, maybe you have flooded the engine. Hold the gas pedal to the floor for 10 seconds (do not pump it) as you crank the engine.

Still no start? Maybe the problem is a stuck needle valve. Tap the carburetor bowl lightly near the gas line, using pliers or a screwdriver handle. This should free the valve so you can start. But if nothing has done the trick so far, move to the next step.

- (10) 2. Check to see if the engine is getting the spark it needs to start. First look for loose or broken spark plug wires. Fix what you can.

If the wires look all right, make a detailed check for a spark. Twist one spark plug boot away from its plug. Push an insulated screwdriver into the boot.

- (15) Hold the shank of the screwdriver about $\frac{1}{8}$ inch away from a metal engine part. Have someone crank the engine. (Be sure you keep your hands away from the

screwdriver shank and the wire to avoid shock.) You'll see a small spark if the ignition system is working. No spark? Get help. (Caution: If there is any gasoline on the engine, be sure you let it evaporate before you try this test.) If you see a

(20) spark, you have eliminated that as a possibility. Move on to the next step.

3. Finally, find out if the carburetor is feeding sufficient air and gasoline to the engine. Remove the top of the air cleaner so you can see the choke plate. If the plate is stuck open, push it shut (only if the engine is cold) and try to start again.

Still no start? Hold the choke wide open and peer deep inside as someone else

(25) pumps the gas pedal. (Make sure he doesn't crank the engine.) If you can't see gas squirting, you need professional help.

1. This type of passage can be described as
 - (A) scientific reading
 - (B) a "how-to" article
 - (C) editorial writing
 - (D) automobile advertising
2. The author's intent in this article is to
 - (A) explain why cars break down
 - (B) warn you about the dangers involved in do-it-yourself car repairs
 - (C) describe the method of checking spark plugs
 - (D) instruct you how to deal with a car problem
3. From the context of the word *crank* (line 16) it must mean
 - (A) complain
 - (B) start
 - (C) turn around
 - (D) shut off
4. List briefly the steps involved in checking the starting mechanism.
 - (A) _____
 - (B) _____
 - (C) _____
 - (D) _____
5. If you check for a spark and don't get one, what should you do?
 - (A) Check the carburetor next.
 - (B) Get an auto mechanic.
 - (C) Clean the gas off the motor.
 - (D) Get a shock.

6. What is the first thing to do when your car doesn't start?
 - (A) Check your gas.
 - (B) Flood the engine.
 - (C) Contact your automobile salesperson.
 - (D) Be sure you're following the rules for starting the car.
7. If you are testing for a spark, gas on the engine is dangerous
 - (A) because it might start the car
 - (B) when it has evaporated
 - (C) after it leaks out of the carburetor
 - (D) because the spark might ignite the gas
8. You should use an insulated screwdriver to
 - (A) protect the engine
 - (B) avoid scratching the metal
 - (C) avoid getting a shock
 - (D) twist the spark plug boot
9. You can unstick a valve by
 - (A) taking it out
 - (B) hitting it
 - (C) loosening it
 - (D) twisting it
10. You have to hold the screwdriver shank away from metal to
 - (A) prevent fire
 - (B) avoid cutting yourself
 - (C) avoid getting a shock
 - (D) check for a bad spark plug
11. Presumably a spark plug *boot* (line 14) is a
 - (A) covering
 - (B) shoe
 - (C) trunk
 - (D) plug
12. It can be inferred that a carburetor
 - (A) is connected to the spark plugs
 - (B) cranks the engine
 - (C) regulates gas and air flow
 - (D) has an open plate

13. If the engine is cold, it is all right to
(A) try to start the car
(B) close the choke plate
(C) take off the air cleaner
(D) pump the gas pedal
14. The choke plate is
(A) next to the gas tank
(B) above the air cleaner
(C) beneath the air cleaner
(D) inside the spark plugs
15. Do you think a person with no understanding of the mechanism of a car could follow these instructions?
Why or why not? _____

Answers

1. The correct answer is (B).
2. The correct answer is (D).
3. The correct answer is (C).
4. (A) Make sure you have gasoline.
(B) Check the valves.
(C) See if the engine is getting a spark. Check the spark plugs.
(D) Find out if the carburetor is feeding enough air and gas to the engine.
5. The correct answer is (B).
6. The correct answer is (D).
7. The correct answer is (D).
8. The correct answer is (C).
9. The correct answer is (B).
10. The correct answer is (C).
11. The correct answer is (A).
12. The correct answer is (C).
13. The correct answer is (B).
14. The correct answer is (C).
15. The correct answer is no. The author assumes that the reader knows something about a car's mechanism.

Sample Reading Passage 8

Questions 1–10 refer to the following restaurant review.

The Banyan Tree, 2 East Monopoly Street ☆

A small sidewalk restaurant on a peaceful back street with a green and white striped awning, rattan chairs, and glass-topped tables. The menu is limited to exotic East Indian specialties, savory curries of all varieties being featured. Full luncheon comes to about \$25. Open daily for lunch only.

The Boathouse, 433 River Road ☆

A delightful, convivial eating place decorated with sea urchin lamps, fishermen's nets, and seaweed wall coverings. Very informal atmosphere. A lighthouse bar. Specialties are, of course, seafood, my favorite being the *moules marinières* served in steaming black pots. A five-course dinner at \$11. Open daily.

Café Henri, 17 Lorraine Street ☆

Soft lighting and muted decorator shades of beige and bronze give the dining room an intimate atmosphere. Basically French, the cuisine represents aromatic country fare, with rich, nutritious soups and assorted platters of sausages, patés, and cheeses. Wholesome fare at reasonable prices. Entrées \$12.50 to \$20.75.

Little Old San Juan, 62 Fortaleza Boulevard ☆☆☆

A cozy Spanish decor, enhanced by mellow, red clay floor tiles, wrought-iron street lanterns, and walls lined with rows of painted pottery, gives this 100-year-old landmark an aura of romantic old Spain. Gazpacho sprinkled with chopped onion, green pepper, rice and garlic croutons, and an irresistible array of Spanish dishes are exceptional. The paella laden with shellfish is more than worth the 30-minute wait. Wines both fine and *ordinario* from the vineyards of Spain. Entrées from \$20. Closed Sundays.

No stars—Fair

☆ Good

☆☆ Very good

☆☆☆ Excellent

☆☆☆☆ Extraordinary

1. You may infer that this guide is
 - (A) a paid-for advertisement
 - (B) written by a restaurant critic
 - (C) an introduction in a cookbook
 - (D) None of the above.

2. The author's intent is to
 - (A) describe gourmet restaurants
 - (B) give the reader a price list for dining out
 - (C) recommend good places to eat
 - (D) warn people about restaurants
3. Which restaurant serves the least expensive meals? _____
4. Which restaurant is recommended most highly? _____
5. Which restaurant is the most expensive? _____
6. Where could you get Indian food? _____
7. Where would you go for shrimp au gratin? _____
8. Which restaurant would most likely have a guitarist? _____
9. Which restaurant sounds like a good place for lovers? _____
10. You would infer that these restaurants are
 - (A) in the United States
 - (B) in Europe
 - (C) for the wealthy only
 - (D) informal

Answers

1. The correct answer is (B).
2. The correct answer is (C).
3. The correct answer is The Boathouse.
4. The correct answer is Little Old San Juan.
5. The correct answer is Little Old San Juan.
6. The correct answer is The Banyan Tree.
7. The correct answer is The Boathouse.
8. The correct answer is Little Old San Juan.
9. The correct answer is Café Henri.
10. The correct answer is (A).

UNDERSTANDING ADVERTISEMENTS

1. List all the places you can think of where you see and hear advertisements for products and services.

Did you name advertising billboards and posters? Where might you see them?

2. Do you have a favorite television commercial? Why do you like it?

Is there a commercial that you particularly dislike? What is it that bothers you about the commercial?

Make a list of at least three features that you consider necessary for a good television commercial.

Writers of advertising copy are amateur psychologists. They know just what will appeal to our instincts and emotions. In general, there are three major areas in our nature at which advertising aims—preservation, pride, and pleasure. Preservation, for example, relates to our innate desire to live longer, know more, and look better. Pride encompasses all sorts of things—our desire to show off, to brag about our prosperity or our good taste, to be one of the *élite*. We all want to enjoy the fruits of our labors, and this is where the pleasure principle comes in. We want to be entertained, to eat and drink well, and to relax in comfortable surroundings.

As you read the following advertisement from the 1980s, look for the means, both *overt* and *subtle*, employed to sell an expensive car.

A CAR SO SWIFT, SILENT AND LUXURIOUS, THAT IT IS, IN EVERY SENSE . . . **BEYOND COMPARISON**

This car stands alone as a class of one. It is, to begin with, the only V-12 powered motorcar for sale in America. Car and Driver described the engine this way: "Its turbinelike smoothness and awesome torque simply set it apart from everything that might attempt to compete, even at half again the price."

The dramatically powerful

engine is teamed with sports car engineering. Power rack and pinion steering is quick and precise. Four wheel independent suspension maintains balance and stability. And four wheel power disc brakes are both smooth and decisive.

The inner world offers an experience of luxury on a level that few drivers will ever know. From the exotic

burled elm veneers that enhance the dashboard and doors to the supple hides that cover virtually all of the passenger compartment, opulence is everywhere. Electronic conveniences pamper you: self adjusting heating and air conditioning; power window, doorlocks and antenna; cruise control and a stereo with signal

scanning tuner are all standard.

Standard too is the best warranty we have ever offered. For two years or 36,000 miles, whichever comes first, we will replace or repair any part which proves defective. The tires are covered by the tire manufacturer's warranty. Your dealer has full details on the limited warranty.

Now look back at the advertisement and use note form to fill in the specific things offered to the purchaser of this car.

1. Show others your wealth.
2. Show your good taste.
3. Get a quality product.
4. Save money.
5. Look beautiful.
6. Be comfortable.
7. Enjoy entertainment.

Advertisements for exotic places to go on your vacation are very different from ads for luxury cars. They must appeal to another side of your nature. After reading the following ad by the Jamaica Tourist Board, answer the questions.

Sample Reading Passage 9

Directions: Questions 1–2 refer to the following advertisement.

JAMAICA

There's no place like home.

Here's you, at home in Jamaica in your very own villa, all pastels and privacy.

With Evangeline to pamper you: she's going shopping soon, to surprise you with a lobster for dinner. Madly extravagant? Not at all.

There are hundreds of villas for rent, all over Jamaica.

Bring your family, or share one with your best friends, and the cost becomes insidiously attractive. And what nicer way to experience the bountiful wonders of Jamaica than to have your own special place to return to each evening, where you can sit back with a rum punch, talk about tomorrow, and say to yourself, "There's no place like home."

Make it Jamaica. Again.

Courtesy of the Jamaica Tourist Board

1. The ad implies that you
 - (A) require entertainment by well-known singers
 - (B) enjoy sightseeing in foreign places
 - (C) don't want to spend a lot of money
 - (D) need a lot of excitement on your vacation
2. The ad appeals to your need for
 - (A) quiet pleasure
 - (B) delicious food
 - (C) relaxation
 - (D) All of the above.

Answers

1. The correct answer is (C).
2. The correct answer is (D).

Sample Reading Passage 10

Directions: Questions 1–5 refer to the following advertisement. Respond to the questions according to the nature of each item.

ONCE-A-YEAR SUMMER SALE! SAVE \$100 OR MORE!

This month only, every membership plan is substantially reduced. That's great! But the real excitement at HRC comes from what people do.

Nautilus

Ours is the most complete and advanced equipment available.

Free Classes

We offer over 120 free classes each week including aerobic and tap dance, calisthenics, yoga and more. You'll also enjoy free clinics in racquetball, squash and tennis. Don't forget about our whirlpools, saunas and swimming pools either.

Guarantee

Come to HRC for 3 days. If all that action leaves you less than satisfied you'll get a full refund.

5 Locations

By the way, your membership allows you to use all 5 locations in Manhattan 7 days a week.

Give us a call or drop by for more information.

Sale Ends Aug. 31st!

NEW YORK HEALTH & RACQUET CLUB

Courtesy of the New York Health & Racquet Club

1. The advertisement emphasizes
 - (A) locations
 - (B) a trial membership
 - (C) reduced cost
 - (D) opening hours
2. It can be inferred that if you join the club
 - (A) the sale ends on August 31
 - (B) you will go to all five club locations
 - (C) your body will improve
 - (D) you will get a refund
3. This ad appeals to people's
 - (A) pleasure
 - (B) pride
 - (C) preservation
 - (D) All of the above.
4. From the context of the expression *free clinics*, it must mean
 - (A) cost-free medical care
 - (B) no charge for lessons
 - (C) liberated movement
 - (D) games
5. Membership in the club enables you to enjoy _____ in winter.
 - (A) the cold
 - (B) a full refund
 - (C) dropping by
 - (D) swimming

Answers

1. The correct answer is (C).
2. The correct answer is (C).
3. The correct answer is (D).
4. The correct answer is (B).
5. The correct answer is (D).

EXERCISES: READING COMPREHENSION SKILLS

Directions: The passages are followed by questions based on their content. Answer the questions on the basis of what is *stated* or *implied* in the passages.

QUESTIONS 1–5 ARE BASED ON THE FOLLOWING PASSAGE.

The business of tennis clothes has grown astoundingly in the past few years. Over \$250 million is spent annually on the trappings of tennis. Apparently everyone wants to look like a pro, even though 20% of the clientele has never even played the game.

- (5) Manufacturers pay the stars lucrative fees for wearing their brands of clothes and wielding their racquets on center court. Chris Evert-Lloyd, for example, was rumored to have signed a five-year contract for \$5 million with Ellesse, a producer of fancy, expensive tennis wear.
- (10) John McEnroe received a reported \$600,000 for playing with a Dunlop racquet, \$330,000 for sporting Tacchini clothes, and \$100,000 for tying his Nike tennis shoes. Obviously, in a bad year, these stars would have made more as fashion models than as athletes.

Not only tennis players get free clothing, but also all the people involved in the game—the referees, linespeople, ball boys and girls—are living advertisements for tennis wear producers. Where, traditionally, conservative white clothing was required for the entire tennis coterie, changing times have seen a new vogue in tennis outfits. Flamboyant colors, designers' nameplates, geometric figures, and bold lines distinguish the new tennis togs from their predecessors.

- (25) 1. It can be inferred from the passage that
- (30) (A) tennis clothing appeals to the wealthy
(B) tennis stars get huge sums for endorsements
(C) the price of tennis racquets has remained stable
(D) bright colors entice people to buy tennis wear

2. The author's intention is to
- (A) explain why the cost of tennis clothes has risen
(B) defend tennis wear manufacturers from complaints about their high prices
(C) describe the means of advertising expensive tennis clothes
(D) describe the new tennis clothing
3. A good title for this passage would be
- (A) The Stars at Play
(B) Big Business in Tennis Wear
(C) The High Cost of Playing Tennis
(D) Tennis Stars' Flamboyant Clothes
4. It is stated that John McEnroe
- (A) wore flamboyant clothing on the court
(B) must have earned over \$1 million for endorsing tennis products
(C) was a fashion model more than he was a tennis player
(D) had had a bad year in tennis competition
5. It is implied that
- (A) tennis clothing is bought by the well-to-do
(B) everyone who wears expensive tennis wear plays tennis
(C) tennis officials would prefer to wear traditional white clothing
(D) fashion models wear tennis clothing

QUESTIONS 6–13 ARE BASED ON THE FOLLOWING PASSAGE WRITTEN IN THE 1980S.

- The oil embargoes of 1973–1975 caused vast chagrin among the manufacturers of automobiles around the world. In particular, American companies were
- (5) obliged to create innovations in producing small cars that would compete in the market with those flowing into the American market from Japan and Europe. No longer could Americans afford
- (10) ostentatious, gas-guzzling vehicles.

- Of paramount importance to today's car owner is the cost of gasoline. American manufacturers have collaborated to supply their clientele with small cars
- (15) that provide the amenities of the stereotyped large American car, yet get better mileage than any other car in the history of American car production. It has become a question of ardently competing with foreign car manufacturers or succumbing to the intense competition and losing a lucrative business through apathy. The American car industry has been rejuvenated. The fuel consumption
- (20) of the new cars has decreased by 49% since 1977; mileage has risen from an average 17.2 miles per gallon to 25.6 miles per gallon. These figures are indicative of a major turnaround in engineering, manufacturing, and design. The industry has made pertinent use of the computer by installing a microprocessor, a thin piece of silicon about the size of an aspirin, in new cars. This miniature computer measures engine speed,
- (30) engine load, and other functions, and sends messages to the fuel system and other parts of the car's mechanism, thus producing lower gas consumption and cleaner exhaust.
- (40)

- By designing sleek, roomy, beautiful, sporty models, the automobile industry has enticed both the average-income and the affluent car buyer into purchasing
- (45) small cars. In addition to saving on gas, today's car is built to save on maintenance and repair expenses. Furthermore, the manufacturer is including the

- costs of maintenance in the buyer's purchase price. New car advertisers now claim that all the buyer has to pay for is gas. To fight corrosion, new coatings have been developed that protect against the havoc caused by road salts, gravel,
- (50) and other materials. Hence, when car owners are ready to turn in last year's car for a new one, they will find that their well-preserved used cars will have an unusually high trade-in value.
- (55)
- Fuel efficient, safe, emission free, economical, and beautiful, today's cars are better bargains than any ever produced before.
- (60)

6. What significance did oil embargoes have in the automobile industry?
- (A) Car manufacturers worldwide had to produce fuel-efficient automobiles.
- (B) Automobile manufacturers had to make smaller cars.
- (C) The Japanese exported cars to America.
- (D) Americans continued to drive American cars.
7. In the second paragraph, there is a statement that implies that
- (A) Americans love large cars
- (B) American auto manufacturers had been indifferent to the need for smaller cars
- (C) Americans will not buy uncomfortable small cars
- (D) All of the above.
8. The microprocessor is
- (A) responsible for the American car industry's rejuvenation
- (B) a major turnaround in American car manufacturing
- (C) a computer that saves gas and helps create cleaner emission
- (D) a pertinent use of fuel consumption

9. According to the passage, small American cars are being bought
- (A) by middle-class and rich clientele
 - (B) because they save fuel
 - (C) because of inflation
 - (D) by Americans who want to help American business
10. According to the passage, new cars are a better bargain than those manufactured in years past because they
- (A) cost less to run and are built to last longer
 - (B) have a built-in computer
 - (C) save fuel, have more safety features, cost less to maintain, and have a higher trade-in value
 - (D) are a lot smaller and don't rust because of better coatings
11. From the information given in the reading, you can infer that anticorrosive coatings will not only protect a new car's body, but also
- (A) make the car run better
 - (B) increase the trade-in value of the car
 - (C) increase the car's mileage
 - (D) make the car safer to drive
12. From the passage you can infer that
- (A) new cars are fuel efficient, sleek, and beautiful
 - (B) Americans want their cars to be both beautiful and practical in terms of comfort and cost
 - (C) Americans will continue to buy European and Japanese cars because they are cheaper
 - (D) if oil becomes plentiful and cheap again, Americans will not return to buying large cars
13. Another inference from the article is that
- (A) the most important consideration in buying a car is the cost of gas
 - (B) gas shortages caused American manufacturers to change their production methods
 - (C) today's cars are more sensible buys than those in the past
 - (D) large cars are more comfortable than small cars

ANSWER KEY

1. B

2. C

3. B

4. B

5. A

6. A

7. D

8. C

9. A

10. C

11. B

12. B

13. C

answers